A Novel

Requiem

For the

Unfiled Motion

He spent a lifetime becoming the man deserving of a woman, only to lose everything in a heartbeat.

A story of unspoken love and crushing weight of "too late", until the clock resets. Waking with the memories of a life lost to regret, a boy is granted a desperate second chance to rewrite fate. No longer content watching from a distance, he must now use his resolve to bridge the gap between what was lost and what could be, fighting to claim a place beside the girl who unknowingly inspired him before the time runs out.

JinAm

Time is the enemy of a heart that hesitates.

Chapter 1

A Name I Never Said

JinAm

Before I knew her name, I already knew her. Not through conversation, not even through distant interaction, but through the gravity of her presence. Eight grade was a year of chaos, identity crises and half-grown limbs. Yet in the middle of all the noise, she was composed. Quiet, but she was the type who could fill a room just by being in it, at least, that is what I think of her. But there was something graceful, measured, timeless, even in her laughter.

I was not alone during that time. I had a group of friends, loud and awkward, the kind who made lunch breaks memorable with dares and arguments over video games. And among them, my best friend: Leon. We talked about everything, whether it's anime, games, food, and life. But not her. Never her. No one noticed. Not Leon, not my other friends. I kept it hidden. I laughed when they laughed, joined teasing, and acted like any crush I had was made-up or far-off. Because this one? It was not something I could joke about. It felt too real. Too scared and fragile. We sat in the middle-right part of the room, like we always do. My desk was worn, scarred with years of carvings and writing from students who are long gone. I rarely spoke unless called on. I did not want to be seen, not out of fear, but out of comfort. There was safety in being invisible. But even shadows have eyes.

The first time I noticed her was during the first quarter of the year. She answered the teacher confidently, her tone laced with sincerity and humor. Everyone laughed, not at her, but because she had that light. I looked at her, stared, and something in me went quiet. I did not know her name. I did not want to know right away. Naming things made them vulnerable, reachable, and real. I was not ready for that. Not yet. But I knew back then that she was everything I was not, and that is why I could not look away.

That year passed in slow, torturous increments. I would wait for glimpse, when she walked past my desk, when she laughed at somethings a friend said, when she raised her hand in class. And I'd pretend not to look, but I was watching, always.

Sometimes, I thought I caught her glancing in my direction. A fleeting moment, maybe. I'd turn away quickly because I was not ready to

be known. Not yet. Then one day, after a brutal periodical math examination, I sat outside during recess, reflecting on every wrong answer in my head. She walked by with her friends, and for a split second, looked at me, and our eyes met. It was not anything cinematic. She did not smile, slow down, talk, or even wave her hand at me. But in that moment, I felt like my heartbeat echoed across our school grounds.

Later that night, staring at my bedroom ceiling in the quiet night, I whispered her name for the first time, just once, like a secret prayer. And I made a promise to the shadows in my room: *"I will become someone worthy of her."*

Chapter 2

Becoming

JinAm

Transformation is not lightning. It's water over dry stone. Slow, persistent, unseen, until one day you look in the mirror and realize you've carved something new out of the old. Not through magic, but through repetition, through intention through countless, invisible battles no one was even aware of.

Ninth grade began without fanfare. Same uniform, same halls, same bell that rang like an echo form a life I was trying to leave behind. But something was different: me. Or rather, something inside me had begun to shift—quietly, persistently.

I joined the Science Club. Not out of passion for chemistry or robotics, but because I needed a place to start. A structure. A doorway. Somewhere, I could stretch beyond the walls I built around myself, walls made of fear, silence, and the comfort of staying unseen. I volunteered to present during meetings, even when my voice trembled and my hands betrayed me, I fumbled. I failed. But I showed up again.

I read books on self-development, on confidence, on psychology, not for random knowledge, but for life lessons. I dissected my fears like they were case studies, practiced smiling without flinching, speaking without retreating, stood in front of the mirror, and tried to become someone I could admire, even if only for a moment. And I journaled, pages filled with questions, regrets, and redirection. A map of my becoming, my improvement, my growth.

I got a haircut that did not look like I'd given up. I started jogging every morning before school. Not for fitness, but for discipline. For ritual. I studied hard, not to compete with others, but because it was a way to reclaim control in a world that often made me feel powerless. Slowly, a new version of myself cover the old me, making me new, reborn, and better than my former self.

I see her less often now. Our paths had diverged, different schedules, different circles. But that did not stop her from haunting the quiet corners of my mind. She remained a lighthouse in the distance, guiding without knowing.

Then the tenth grade arrived and the world paused. A pandemic spread across the globe like a slow-moving tide, swallowing everything familiar. Schools closed, streets emptied, screen replaced faces, and what was once ordinary became uncertain.

But in that stillness, I found something unexpected: clarity.

I had time now, uncut, uninterrupted time to build myself, brick by careful brick. I learned to code. Enrolled in online courses about philosophy, psychology, and history. I read books not because I had tom but because I wanted to understand. I taught myself how to meditate, how to befriend my thoughts. I started writing prose, essays, and fragments of reflections. I created routines when the world lost all rhythm.

While others waited for normal to return, I tried to become someone new.

I never spoke to her. We were not friends. We were not even acquaintances. She's in front of a different screen, logged into a different classroom, perhaps unaware of my existence, and yet, she remained the quiet flame I orbited around, the impossible standard, the imagined audience, the muse that demanded I be more.

The pandemic taught me many things: How to be alone without being lonely, how to endure long silence without shrinking, how to plant seeds in soil no one else could see, but most of all, it taught me that becoming someone worthy of love is not about love itself. It is about motion. It is about pursuit.

And so, I pursued.

Not just for her. Not entirely. But because chasing the impossible made it possible.

Chapter 3

Breaking Through

JinAm

Eleventh grade arrived without ceremony. No return to the familiar click of classroom doors, no rustle of uniforms in crowded hallways. Just the soft glow of screens and the sterile quiet of online waiting rooms. Still remote. Still fragile. Still stitched together by the internet and willpower.

But I had changed.

Not all at once. Not in some dramatic transformation. But slowly, over time, like a shoreline reshaped by the tide. The old version of me, the one who kept his camera off, who disappeared behind silence, was fading. I did not need anyone to notice it. It was enough that I did.

So I turned on my camera. Not every time, but more, and more. At first, it felt like exposure, like vulnerability, like risk. But then it became something else: presence. A quiet act of showing up. A way to say, I am still here, I am still trying.

I began answering questions aloud, even if I stumbled. I figure it was better to be wrong and learning than right and invisible. I noticed others struggling too, names that ever lit up, voices that never broke through the static. So, I messaged them. Checked in. Started a group chat for our class. We shared notes, reminders, and small encouragement.

At first, there were just five of us. Then ten. Then more. The chat turned into late-night discussions, study calls, and a kind of unofficial family, a patchwork of students who refused to let silence win.

I applied for a leadership position in virtual clubs, made short campaign videos, and wrote speeches. Part of me still thought I would not make it, but I did. Not because I was loud or popular, but because I cared and kept showing up.

She was not part of that world anymore. We had gone to different senior high schools. The algorithm of life had shuffled us apart. I did not know where she studied now, what classes she took, what kind of people surrounded her. I didn't even know if she remembered me.

But I remembered her.

She no longer haunted my thoughts the way she used to. Her presence had shifted. She had become something deeper—an anchor, a compass. Less a person, more a force. The reason I started, even if she was not the reason I continued.

She was the spark. The fuse. The first breath of movement after stillness.

Twelfth grade came heavy. There was no easing into it. College applications, scholarship forms, competitive exams—all of it pressing down like a weight on the chest. Everyone was scrambling, racing, trying to measure up. I felt it too. The need to prove something. To prove that the version of me I'd built was not just temporary.

When it came time to choose a research topic, I did not play it safe. I picked one that scared me. One that would push me into unfamiliar territory. One I could not complete by coasting.

It consumed me.

I worked on it late into the night. I rewrote the methodology a dozen times. I ran simulations. Compared datasets. Checked for inconsistencies. Proofread every sentence like it were sacred. My group began to rely on me for everything—not because they were incapable, but because I had made myself reliable. I didn't complain. I led. Quietly. With intention.

We submitted the final paper with nerves in our throats. And when the results came back, we won. First place. Recognized across campuses. Cited in newsletters and shared on forums. My name was printed under the title. "Best in Research."

Graduation day came hot and electric. The sun was merciless, but no one cared. Families filled the auditorium. Students in robes buzzed like bees. The air held joy. Cameras clicked. Names were shouted. Teachers wore real smiles, not the exhausted ones from screens.

Then they said mine.

I stood and walked to the stage. The crowd erupted louder than I expected. It was not forced. It was not the kind of applause that came from obligation. It felt genuine. I scanned their faces as I moved forward—my classmates, my teachers, people who had seen me quiet, hesitant, now watching me rise.

A teacher placed the medal around my neck. It was cold. Weighted. Not just with metal, but with meaning.

I stood there for a second too long, looking out into the sea of faces. I knew she wasn't among them. But I imagined her anyway. I pictured her sitting in the back, arms folded, eyes fixed. Not clapping. Just watching. A witness, not a fan.

In that moment, I was not a boy chasing an impossible crush. I was someone who had made something out of longing. Who had taken a silent infatuation and built a life from it.

"I did this because of you.", I said silently. "You were the first reason I wanted to be seen. The first reason I believed I could be more."

I walked off the stage. The medal thudded softly against my chest, each step echoing with something I could not quite name.

It was not just an award.

It was a turning point.

It was the end of the old story.

And the beginning of the new one.

Chapter 4

From The Ashes

JinAm

College started with a strange, weightless feeling. I entered First Year ready, not with confidence, but with determination. I joined the student council as part of the media committee. I wanted to be behind the scenes, to contribute without standing in the spotlight. I poured my energy into graphic design, posters, and publication materials. I designed layouts, edited graphics, and created content for school events.

And then, something unexpected happened. Professors began recognizing my work. Students approached me, complimented me on the layout, and asked for help with their projects. I, the once-invisible boy, was suddenly someone known.

It was overwhelming. But it was also empowering.

My work became my voice. Through my designs, I communicated stories, themes, and values. I made new friends, built new routines, and became part of something. I was no longer the quiet kid hiding in the back row. I had found a role that felt right, where I could make a difference.

Then Second Year came, and with it, something bigger: I was elected Public Information Officer. It meant more responsibilities—writing statements, handling communications, managing publicity for events. I had to lead a team, coordinate with departments, and speak in front of audiences.

It was terrifying. But it also felt like a turning point. I was trusted. I was visible. I was respected.

And still, I thought of her. Not constantly, but often. Even though I had not seen her in years—not during senior high, not during college, we attended different schools. She remained a silent force behind every accomplishment.

I did not talk about her to anyone. Not because I was hiding something, but because it felt sacred. Like if I said her name out loud, the spell would break, and she'd vanish from my memory entirely.

In an effort to forget her—I let myself open to someone new. She was kind, witty, and always knew the right thing to say. She noticed the details, asked how I was doing without expecting surface-level

answers. We talked, laughed, and shared silence that did not feel empty. And for a while, I thought maybe… just maybe, I could stop looking for someone who no longer even knew I existed.

But even at my happiest with her, there was always a shadow in the room. A memory, a ghost, a name I still could not say aloud. I tried. I did. But when the heart's blueprint is carved by one person, it's hard to redraw it without the lines showing.

She noticed. And she deserved better than to be someone's escape. So, I let her go.

I did not cry. I did not beg. I just… let her go, quietly. Because some goodbyes are not about endings, they are acknowledgements that we are still haunted by things we thought we have buried.

Still, I moved forward. The boy I was in eighth grade? He would never have believed any of this. And that thought kept me going. I kept learning. I kept designing. I kept building the life I imagined someone like her might notice. Even if she never did.

Then, Third Year arrived. My name began circulating more often, on emails, in meetings, whispered among students who wanted to collaborate. I was no longer someone who simply contributed; I was someone they relied on.

But no matter how far I went, or how wide the circle around me grew, my world always had a center. And that center was still her.

She was the silent reel behind the highlights of my growth. The imagined audience of my proudest moments. I did not need her applaud; I just needed her to exist somewhere in the story. Even if we never spoke again.

Then came Fourth Year. Internship season.

I was not expecting anything special. Just another requirement, another bullet point on the résumé. I walked into orientation with a clipboard in hand and the exhaustion of someone who'd carried too much for too long.

Until I saw a name in the list. Hers.

At first, I thought it was a coincidence. A duplicate. A glitch.

But my fingers froze. My breath stalled.

It was not just the name—it was the handwriting on the attendance sheet. Familiar, looping, slightly rushed. It was the way my heart reacted—not confused, not anxious, but alert. Like some forgotten part of me had just been woken up.

And then I looked up.

And she was there.

Standing by the door, sunlight casting soft edges around her frame. She was older. Brighter. Sill unmistakably her.

Her hair was longer. Her posture is more grounded. There was something in her face that had not been there before—maybe clarity, maybe calm. Maybe just time.

And yet, the second our eyes met, all the years folded like paper.

I froze. Not in fear, but in awe.

It was like watching a dream return to reality. A chapter I thought I's closed. Opening itself up again, word by word.

She looked at me.

Not through me.

Not past me.

At me.

And then she smiled.

That smile—God, I remembered it. The one that made me believe in goodness. The one that used to live in my memory like a locked box I'd stopped trying to open.

And just like that, The weight I had been carrying did not disappear… but it shifted.

Because now, she was real again.

And for the first time in years, I did not feel like I was chasing a ghost.

I was standing face-to-face with her.

My multo.

Alive.

And here.

Chapter 5

In Another Universe—Maybe…

JinAm

Eight years.

That is how long it had been since I last saw her. She had disappeared into a different school and a different life while I stayed and tried to become someone worth remembering. And event though we had not crossed paths in all that time, she had never truly left.

Because she was my multo.

Not a ghost in the tragic sense, but a presence that trailed behind every version of me I tried to grow into. She was in the silences between victories, in the spaces where my motivation burned brightest. She was the unspoken reason behind my late-night grind, behind the way I sat straighter when I presented, behind the quiet determination to never fade into the background again.

When the government internship was announced, I did not expect anything except another bullet point on my résumé. I had been serving as Public Information Officer for the student council, had a portfolio of graphic design and published works, and my name ws starting to carry a little weight in campus circles. Professors knew me. Students sought me out. I had long shed the invisibility of my eighth-grade self.

And yet… the moment I saw her name on the participants list, everything paused.

She was back. Not by fate, not by accident, but by some cruel, quiet twist of the universe that knew I was not ready, and sent her anyway.

When we met again, she looked older, more sure of herself. Her laugh still cut through the air like music I had not heard for years. For a moment, I thought maybe I had imagined all of it—my feelings, the journey, the quiet devotion. But then she looked at me and said, *"You've changed."*

I laughed softly. *"You're the reason why."*

She blinked, the surprise in her eyes barely concealed. And before the moment could slip past us, I added, *"I liked you. Back in eighth grade. You*

didn't notice, and I never said anything… but I carried it. For years. And I changed because of it. Because of you."

Her lips parted slightly. *"I… I had no idea."*

"Of course not," I said with a half-smile. *"I never gave you the chance to."*

We worked on the same team. Not close, not always side-by-side, but close enough for me to notice how different we both were. I caught her looking at me during briefings. And just for a moment, I allowed myself to hope. Maybe this was the time the story finally caught up to us.

But one evening, when the day had bled into dusk and the sky had turned the color of regret, we sat together outside the office. We were both tired. I do not even remember who spoke first.

What I remember is her voice when she said it: *"I'm not alone anymore."*

A simple sentence. No flourish. No drama. Just the truth.

She had someone. Had for a while.

The hope I did not even know I had been nursing flickered once, then vanished. There was no heartbreak, not the kind that rips and breaks. Just a quiet unraveling. Like a balloon I had been holding for too long, finally drifting out of reach.

"You don't have to be sorry," I said after a while. *"I think some part of me always knew."*

She turned to me then, with that same warmth she had carried years ago. *"Still… if you had told me back then—If I had known—I think I could have reciprocated your feelings."*

And that hurt more than any rejection. Because it was not a no, it was a "too late."

Before the moment ended, I smiled and nodded. *"It's okay. Really. Knowing that is enough."*

I did not expect anything more after that. But a few days later I found a letter tucked inside my folder—her handwriting unmistakable.

I read it alone, under the dim flicker of my desk lamp.

"—,

Your words made me stop. Not just pause, but stop—like the kind of pause where you suddenly become aware of your breathing. I had to take a moment to absorb it all.

I didn't expect you to say any of that. And the fact that you said it to my face? Grabe. I never imagined someone would hold on to a version of me for that long. Let alone let it shape their future.

I didn't know you liked me in 8th grade. I didn't know I meant that much to you. And honestly? If you had told me then… I think I could've felt the same way.

Maybe we could've been something.

But I guess we're both too late now.

Still, thank you. For changing. For growing. For remembering me in silence. I'm proud of who you became—even if I wasn't there to see it all.

You're not invisible anymore. You never were. I just wasn't looking in the right direction.

—Yours, maybe in another life, another universe

Your Multo."

I folded the letter and pressed it to my chest, eyes closed.

She was my multo. The silent reason I kept becoming. And though she belonged to someone else now, I no longer needed her to complete the story.

Because I had already lived that story.

And that was enough.

But still… I love her with all my heart, and that love will never fade.

I love you… I loved you…

Chapter 6

Through The Years: The Ghost of My Past

JinAm

Time had passed, but it still felt like I had never truly left that place. I wondered if it was possible to stand still and move forward at the same time. As I walked through the campus, the familiar faces, the old halls, everything felt like a strange echo of my past. The bot I had been, the one who could not even say her name without feeling the weight of every unsent word, seemed so far away now. But every step I took felt like I was stepping back into that old version of myself, even as the world around me kept shifting, growing.

I had learned to smile at the things that once caused me pain. I had leaned that some wounds don't heal, they just change. They become part of who you are, woven into your history, etched into your heart. And while I had moved forward, there was always a part of me that stayed rooted in the past.

The thought of her still haunts me, like a ghost.

It was not something that consumed me, not anymore. But there were nights, sometimes, when I could still feel her presence, a whisper in the quiet, a shadow in the corner of my mind. It was like she was always just out of reach, not a person, but an idea, a possibility that had been erased before it had even begun.

As the years went on, I found myself wondering if things could have been different, if we could have been something else, in another life, in another universe. I thought about the "what-ifs" that would never have answers. Maybe she could have felt the same way, maybe she could have been the one who had been there for me when I needed her most. Maybe we could have built a future together, something that did not feel like a dream.

But that was the painful truth of it all—we were never meant to be. And it was not for a lack of trying, not for me at least. I tried to move on, tried to let go, and in many ways, I did. I found new people, built new relationships, and created new memories. But there were still days when her name lingered in my chest, heavy and unspoken.

I did not know if I would ever fully let go, but I had learned to live with it.

And then, one day, as if the universe had heard my silent plea, I saw her again. It was not dramatic, no grand reunion, no signs flashing in the sky. It was just a moment, a fleeting instant. We bumped into each other on the sidewalk, and for a brief second, I saw her as she was before: full of life, the same laugh that still felt like music to my ears. Her eyes met mine, and in that split second, everything came flooding back.

But we did not say anything.

She smile softly, a smile that felt both familiar and distant, like something I had been waiting to see for years but could never quite touch. And then, as quickly as it happened, she was gone. Like a dream that fades as soon as you wake up.

In that moment, I realized something that I had always known, deep down, that we were not meant to share a future. Our paths had crossed for a reason, but it was not to stay intertwined. We were two separate lives that had briefly brushed against each other and then drifted apart. There was no tragedy in that. No heartbreak, no sense of unfinished business.

It was simply the way of things.

The space between us was wide now, filled with time, with growth, with memories of who we were, and who we had become. There was no anger, no longing, no regret. Just the quiet understanding that I have moved on.

As I stood there, watching her disappear into the crowd, I felt a kind of peace. I had always carried her with me, but I did not need her to define me anymore. I had lived my story, with or without her. And that was enough

I had finally learned that sometimes, the stories that hurt the most are the ones we let go of. And the ones we never get to finish.

But maybe, in another universe—maybe, there was a version of us where we had more time. More chances. A future that never slipped through our fingers.

And for the first time. I let myself believe it.

It was enough.

Chapter 7

Objection of Fate: My Final Case, The One I Never Won

JinAm

Years have passed…

The night air was thick with rain, each drop tapping rhythmically against the windshield like a metronome counting down the seconds I did not have. The city lights outside smeared into streaks, blurring through the droplets, just as my thoughts blurred between moments past and a future I would never see.

The weight of the day pressed down on me. Hours spent poring over legal briefs, fighting battles in court, carrying the hopes and fears of others on my shoulders. The fight to rise from the awkward, insecure bot I was in junior high to the man I'd become was not just a story of self-growth. It was a tale written by her, the girl I never truly dared to hold, but who shaped everything I was and everything I wished to be.

Tonight was supposed to be different.

I had just come from a late meeting, finalizing a case that could have meant a promotion, one step closer to the life I had dreamed of while studying in college, balancing student council duties and long nights of research. But the familiar ache settled in my chest, the ache of a love never spoken aloud, a love that haunted every success, every lonely moment.

The road stretched ahead, slick and unforgiving under the rain. My fingers clenched the steering wheel tighter, a futile attempt to steady the turmoil inside me. I could still hear her voice from years ago, the way it softened when she laughed, the warmth in her eyes when we met again during that government OJT in our fourth year of college, the moment our paths crossed once more.

But this time, I had the courage. This time, I thought, it could be different.

Then, everything shattered.

A sudden glare of headlights cut through the darkness. A car swerved recklessly, coming head-on without warning. My body reacted before my mind could process, jerking the wheel sharply. The world exploded into chaos.

Metal collided with metal in a savage, unforgiving scream. The deafening crunch of the crash filled my ears as glass burst, raining like cold

fire around me. My head slammed against the side window, pain erupting like a star gone supernova.

But worse than the physical torment was the crushing realization that this might be the end—the end of the story I was not ready to finish.

I tried to speak, but my throat was thick, words caught like desperate gasps. I thought of her, the shy girl who unknowingly sparked a revolution in my soul. The girl I pursued silently from eighth grade, whose existence rewrote my destiny.

My vision blurred, pain radiating through every nerve ending. I wanted to tell her. No. I needed to tell her. To tell her that I loved her, that everything I had done was because of her.

I remembered the proud moments: my senior high school graduation, the night I received high honor and the Best in Research award, the thunderous applause for a boy who once doubted his worth. The years in college, filled with laughter and struggles, where I served as a student council officer, learning leadership and responsibility—and always holding her in my heart.

But all those moments, all those triumphs, suddenly felt so fragile, like a delicate glass sculpture in a single instant.

The world tilted, the rain on the broken windshield blending with tears I could not shed. Sirens wailed in the distance, but their cries felt like they were coming from another life.

I wanted more time. To rewrite the past, to fix the mistakes, to tell her I was not just the bot who admired her from afar, but a man willing to fight for what mattered.

A part of me screamed against the dark closing in, but the pain grew heavier, dragging me down like an anchor to a deep, cold sea.

As my breathing slowed, a whisper escaped my cracked lips—an apology to the life I was leaving behind and the love I had never fully claimed.

And in that final moment, with the city lights fading to black, I understood the cruelest truth: some stories do not get their happy endings. Not here. Not now.

But maybe, somewhere beyond this fragile existence, there was another chance, a different path where I could rise again, stronger, braver, ready to hold her hand and never let go.

The cold darkness swallowed me whole.

Then, suddenly, I gasped. Lungs burning, eyes snapping open.

I was not in that shattered car anymore.

I was back.

Back in a classroom bathed in soft afternoon light, the scent of old textbooks and dust filling my senses. The familiar chatter of eighth graders buzzed around me, and there she was, unaware, unknowingly the catalyst of the future yet unwritten.

My heart hammered, not with fear, but with fierce resolve.

This time, I would not be the boy who only watched from afar.

This time, I will rewrite everything.

Because death was not the end.

It was only the beginning.

Chapter 8

The Last Second

JinAm

I died

Not in a way people write about—no fading edges of light, no golden warmth, no mysterious tunnel lined with ancestral whispers. Just the cold, sharp crack of metal, the sickening twist of physics gone wrong, and then the silence. A silence so final it was not absence, but presence, something that wrapped around me like a closing curtain.

It was not even a full thought that passed through me at the end. Not a memory. Not a name.

Just a whisper:

If only I had…

That was it.

No farewell. No flashback montage. Just the sick, aching wish that I had been braver.

Braver when it mattered.

Braver for her.

Then, nothing. Not a dream, not even darkness. Oblivion.

But only for a moment.

Because the universe, in whatever broken mercy it held, was not done with me.

There was no gentle awakening. It was a gasp. A ragged, sucking-in of air. My lungs seized, shocked to find breath again. My chest convulsed like it had been punched from the inside, Light slammed into my eyes, I flinched.

The came the sound.

First, the rays of fluorescent lights, familiar in a way that made my skin crawl.

Then whiteboard marker on board. A teacher's voice, muffled by routine. The rustle of notebooks. The occasional cough. Pens scratching paper.

And the smell. Dust, whiteboard markers, a faint trace of fabric softener and adolescent sweat. Too familiar. Too real.

I opened my eyes.

And I was there.

Second row from the window. Standard-issue student desk. The same seat I had always taken back in…

Back in eighth grade.

I stared at my own hands. Smaller. Softer. The fingers not yet hardened by years of teaching and law practice, not yet shaped by confidence or time. I turned then over slowly, as if I did not quite believe they were mine.

The pen in my grip wobbled slightly. Black Bic. The cheap kind we used to chew the caps of.

This was not a dream. Dreams do not have this much weight. This much dust in the air. This much gravity.

The marker squeaked. A classmate shifted behind me. The fan above rotated lazily, whining on its rusted axle.

Then—

"Jin?"

A voice.

Her voice.

I froze.

It was soft, curious, like wind touching windchimes, recognizable in a way the made my breath hitch.

I turned.

There she was.

God.

Her hair fell loosely over her shoulder, caught in a ponytail that was already half-undone. Her eyes were bright, not the polished confidence o her older self, but the distracted, daydreamy sharpness of youth. She stared at me like I was acting weird, which in fairness, I absolutely was.

Time had not just turned back.

It had resurrected her. Rebuilt her in the image I had memorized a thousand times through fading memories and blurred yearbook photos.

She looked exactly how I remembered.

Maybe even brighter.

"Are you okay?" she asked, brow lifting.

I opened my mouth, but no sound came. Not right away. My mind racing, trying to catch up to the impossible.

This was not a dream.

This was her.

This was then

I was here.

"I—uh… yeah," I managed.

She blinked, smiled, confused but not unfriendly. "Okay… weird."

And just like that, she turned back to her notebook, doodling little stars in the margin while pretending to pay attention.

I sat there, stunned.

This was the moment. The age. Where everything had begun.

Where I first saw her and something shifted inside me. Where I first dared to want something so badly I was scared to even say it. Where silence had seemed safer than rejection. Where I watched from a distance and told myself it was enough.

And now I am back.

Back with years of memories and regrets carved into me like tree rings. Back with the knowledge of who she would become, and who I would fail to be in time to deserve her.

But none of that had happened yet.

The universe gave me something impossible: a restart.

A second chance.

I felt my throat tighten. Not with fear, but with something else. A tremble. A promise. A vow trying to form in my chest.

This time, I would not waste it.

This time, I would not admire her from the shadows. I would not carry her weight into every version of my future. I would not let the moment pass and tell myself it was not the right time.

Because time already killed me once.

Not again.

I looked at her, at the girl who unknowingly lit the path I walked for years after she was gone.

She was here.

And so was I.

And even if the universe was playing some cruel trick… I was going to fight for this life.

No more ghosts.

I looked out the window, sunlight pooling on the edge of my desk like spilled gold.

I died.

But maybe that was what it took to finally live.

Chapter 9

Silence, Shattered

JinAm

The bell rang, an abrupt, metallic sound that scattered through the hallways and broke the spell of nostalgia. Students groaned, stretched, packed their bags with the lethargy of kids who did not yet know how precious slow days could be.

I sat still.

I was breathing, but everything inside me was trembling.

This was not a dream. It was real. As real as the smudge of ink on my hands, the creak of cheap chairs scraping the floor, the notebook in front of me with notes I had not written in decades. I flipped through it absently, finding doodles of swords and fireballs, a kid's mind still half in fantasy worlds, not yet scarred by the weight of real life.

And then there was her.

She stood up, lazily slinging her bag over one shoulder. She had not changed at all. No, scratch that, I was the one who had changed, a man packed tightly into a boy's skin, carrying memories too large for these corridors.

She glanced at me again, curious. *"You're being weird,"* she said. *"You sure you're okay?"*

I opened my mouth, then closed it. The words were jammed at the base of my throat like traffic in a tunnel.

"Yeah," I finally croaked. *"Just… tired."*

She gave me that amused look, the one she always gave back then. It had not meant anything special at the time. But now, it felt like an echo across timelines.

She walked off toward the door, her steps as carefree as ever. I watched her go, heart thudding like it had not stopped since the accident.

No. Since the resurrection.

I wandered the halls in a daze.

Everything was smaller.

The ceilings were not as high. The lockers were not as intimidating. Event the teacher's voices lacked that heavy authority they once carried.

I passes familiar faces—kids I had not thought about in years. Some would become friends, others strangers. A few, I now knew, would vanish too soon. I wanted to stop and talk to them, shake their hands, and warn them. But what could I say that would not make me sound insane?

I found my way to the restroom and splashed water on my face. The boy in the mirror was not who I remember. Rounder cheeks. Softer features. The fire in my eyes had not sparked yet.

And yet, beneath the surface, I could feel the man inside screaming: *"This is your shot. Don't mess it up this time."*

At home, everything was frozen in time.

My bedroom had posters of games I no longer play. My laptop ran like a snail. My mom called me from the kitchen, her voice tinged with a warmth I had not heard in years.

"*Dinner's ready!*"

I almost cried.

Not because I missed the food. But because I knew how many meals I would take for granted in the years to come.

Sitting at the table, I stared at my parents. I watched their small talks, the way my dad sipped from a chipped mug, the way my mom scraped rice from the pot. I memorized these things. They were ghosts in my original timeline, and now they were warm flesh and bone again.

That night, I could not sleep.

My heart kept circling back to her.

She was here. I could reach out, speak to her, change everything. But how? If I moved too fast, I'd scare her. If I waited too long, I'd repeat the past.

I had a second chance.

But no manual.

The next day, I showed up to school early. Too early. The janitor had not even unlocked all the rooms yet. I stood by the basketball court, watching the sun rise like it owed me something.

She arrived late. Like always.

And again, our eyes met.

This time, I smiled first.

"Morning," I said.

She tilted her head. *"Wow. You're early. What happened? Alarm clock exploded?"*

I chuckled. *"Just wanted to get a head start."*

She blinked. Something about my tone caught her off guard, I think.

"Well, look at you," she said, teasing. *"Turning into a model student now?"*

"I'm trying." I smiled again, slower this time. *"Trying to be better."*

She did not answer, but I saw something flicker in her expression—curiosity.

It was a start.

The days passed like that, me walking the tightrope between familiarity and change. I was still the quiet boy. But this time, I made the effort to sit beside her during group work. To laugh at her jokes. To tell her about the sky when it turned a certain color.

I did not flirt. I did not push. I was just there.

Because I knew how time worked now.

And I knew I'd lose her again if I did not start laying the bricks slowly, carefully, with the reverence of someone rebuilding a house from ruins.

One afternoon, we sat by the window while everyone else was on lunch break.

She glanced at me. *"You're different lately."*

I pretended to think. *"Different good?"*

She shrugged. *"Not sure yet. But not bad."*

Silence fell between us, but not the kind that chokes. This one was easy.

Comfortable.

I turned to her, the words on the tip of my tongue. I died. I came back. For you.

But I said instead, *"You ever thing about the future?"*

She looked at me. *"Sometimes. Why?"*

"I think about it a lot," I said. *"And I wonder… what would happen if we didn't waste time pretending we didn't care."*

Her brow furrowed. *"What do you mean?"*

I shrugged. *"Nothing. Just a thought."*

She was quiet for a while. Then she smiled, small, hesitant, like a sunbeam peeking through a storm cloud.

"You're weird lately," she said.

I laughed. *"You have no idea."*

That night, I wrote it all down in a notebook.

Every moment. Every word.

Because this time, I would not forget.

And I would not lose her.

Even if I had to burn every second of silence that once kept me away.

Chapter 10

The Shape of Her Name

JinAm

Morning became rituals.

I would wake up in my old bed, sunlight leaking through the curtains like the world was apologizing for all it had taken. The smell of my mother's cooking seeped through the walls. A television murmured from the living room—same shows, same laugh tracks. But everything felt different now. More delicate. More urgent.

Every moment held weight.

At school, I began to study her without meaning to. The way she twirled her pen when she was bored. The little bounce in her step when she walked. How her laughter started low, like a secret, then burst into something you could feel in your ribs. She did not know that I had watched this before. That I had memorized it once, lost it, and now was memorizing it again like a language I thought I had forgotten.

I did not speak of my second life. How could I? It was not just unbelievable, it was unbearable to think of going through all that again if I failed.

So instead, I became careful.

More present. But never desperate.

She started sitting closer in group projects. Asking if I was free during breaks. It was subtle, not quite affection, not yet attachment. But something was there. A change in the wind, the scent of a storm before it breaks.

And for the first time in years—even across two lifetimes—I let myself hope.

One day, during recess, she tapped my shoulder.

"Come with me."

I blinked. *"Where?"*

"Roof," she said. *"We're not supposed to, but… rules are just suggestions, right?"*

I smiled. *"Since when did you become a rebel?"*

She grinned. *"Since now."*

We slipped past the stairwell gate when the teachers were not looking, climbed to the rook, and emerged into the sky. The city stretched beneath us, cluttered and imperfect. The wind tugged at out uniforms.

She stood but the railings, eyes closed, arms wide like she was about to fly.

"I like it here," she said. *"No noise. Just wind and height."*

"You're not afraid of heights?"

She opened her eyes and looked at me. *"You only fall I you want to."*

And maybe I did. Maybe I already was.

We did not speak for a while. She just leaned against the railing, watching clouds drift. I sat on the concrete, watching her instead.

"You've changed," she said suddenly.

I blinked. *"How?"*

"You're quieter. But not in the same way. It's like… you listen harder now. Like you're paying attention."

I swallowed *"Maybe I finally learned how."*

She turned to face me. *"I thing I like this you better."*

And in that moment, something softened me. A wall I had carried from the last life began to crumble, not all at once, but enough to let light through.

In the days that followed, she began sharing things. Small things. A favorite song. A book she dog-eared to death. How she hated silence, but like mine.

We walked the hallways like threads slowly weaving together. Nothing official. No declarations. But there were pauses when we talked

that meant more than words, glances that lingered like the universe had tilted slightly in my favor.

I wanted to tell her everything. That I had once lost her. That I had failed to even speak. That in another timeline, I had become someone she would never know.

But instead, I just walked beside her. Because this time, I was here.

And maybe that was enough.

One afternoon, rain poured suddenly. Most of our classmates ran for cover, but she stayed under the tree near the gate, laughing as the drops hit her hair, her shoulders, her shoes.

I ran to her with my jacket. *"You're gonna get sick."*

"I don't care," she said. *"If feels real."*

I held the jacket over both of us, close enough that I could see the raindrops hanging on her lashes. Her smile faded slightly, replaced by something quieter.

"Do you ever feel like you're in the wrong time?" she asked. *"Like… you were supposed to be somewhere else, but the world placed you here by mistake?"*

I stared at her. *"Every day."*

We stood there, jacket stretched between us, the rest of the world blurred in water and wind.

"If you were in the right time," she said softly, *"what would you do?"*

I hesitated. *"I'd tell you something."*

She looked up. *"Like what?"*

And for a second, I almost did. I almost told her everything: my death, my return, my second chance. How every heartbeat I had now was stitched with her name.

But the words stopped in my throat. Too heavy. Too much.

Instead, I just said," That *I'm glad I met you now. That maybe… this is where I'm supposed to be."*

Her smile returned, this time smaller, sadder. But she nodded. *"Me too."*

Later that night, I sat by my winder, notebook open.

I wrote her name over and over. Not in hearts, not in poems. Just her name.

Because I had learned that sometimes, the simplest thing held the most weight.

A name, remembered.

Spoken.

Cherished.

And never forgotten.

I would not waste this life. Not this time. Not when her laughter could still reach me in the rain.

Not when I had seen a world without it.

Chapter 11

The Shape of a Second Chance

JinAm

It had been weeks since I woke in this boy's body, weeks of reliving middle school moments that once felt insignificant, now brimming with quiet gravity. I moved through each day carefully, like a man walking through the ashes of a house he once burned down. Every hallway, every scent of floor polish or cafeteria food, every laugh I used to ignore felt sacred now.

Because this time, I knew what I had. And what I could lose.

I studied her.

Not with the wide-eyed infatuation of an eighth grader, but with the reverence of a soul who had tasted death and found life again in the tilt of her smile.

She was beginning to notice.

There were moments, small as they were, when her glances lingered. When our eyes met and she did not look away. When my presence, once easy to overlook, now pulled something silent from her.

I did not push. I did not confess.

Instead, I rewrote the story in strokes: subtle, patient, and sure.

That morning, I waited outside the gate. I knew she liked walking slowly. I knew she hated mornings, especially Mondays. So, I brought her a warm cup of milk tea from the canteen.

She blinked. *"What's this?"*

"Your Monday survival kit," I said.

She squinted at me like I had grown two heads, then slowly, reluctantly, took it.

"You're so weird lately," she muttered.

"You keep saying that," I smiled. *"But you're still talking to me."*

She looked at the drink. Then at me. *"Don't get too cocky."*

I did not. I just walked beside her, letting our silence settle like dust between footsteps.

That was the thing about her. She did not need grand gestures. She noticed the quiet ones.

The way I stood closer now.

The way I remembered her favorite color. The way I folded my arms when she spoke, to keep from reaching out without permission.

It was all building toward something.

Something I had not dared hoped for, not even when I found myself breathing again in this timeline.

One afternoon, a storm rolled in before dismissal. The kind of storm that turned skies purple and roads to rivers. We were stuck under the covered walk, waiting with the others, but she looked cold, her arms wrapped tight around her.

I hesitated. Then took of my jacket.

"Here."

She looked at it. At me. At the rain.

"I'm fine," she said.

"I know," I said, *"but let me be kind anyway."*

And that—those words—landed differently.

She wore the jacket. Quietly. Her eyes did not meet mine. But her fingers brushed mine as she took it.

And I felt it: the hinge of something turning.

That night, I lay in bed staring at the ceiling. My heart felt like it was too big for my chest.

I was not falling for her.

I already had.

In a life long buried under years and regret and roads I never walked down. But here, now, I was allowed to love her again.

And this time, I would not lose my voice.

I would not let the moments pass.

So I wrote her a letter.

Not a confession, but a story.

It was about two stars caught in separate orbits, always circling, never touching. Until one night, the sky cracked open, and the stars were pulled toward each other.

In the end, they did not collide.

They danced.

And maybe they would burn for it.

But oh, what a light they made.

I folded it into three parts and tucked it into my notebook.

The next day, I planned to slip it into her bag. Quietly. Nameless.

Just something to reach her heart before my voice could.

But the universe, in its bitter humor, never makes it that simple.

Because the next morning, she was not there.

Absent. Just… gone.

My chest caved. Fear wrapped itself around my ribs.

I asked around. A fever, they said. Home for a few days.

I walked home that afternoon slower than ever.

The air felt heavier. As if time itself had paused, waiting for her return.

I looked at the letter again that night.

And rewrote it.

Not to make it perfect.

But to make it true.

Three days later, she was back.

Pale, tired, hair tied back lazily—but smiling when I caught her eye.

I almost ran.

Almost.

Instead, I walked up beside her as she dug through her bag for a pen.

"Welcome back," I said, trying to keep my voice steady.

She looked at me. "Missed me?"

"Terribly."

She blinked. Laughed. "You're braver lately."

I shrugged. "Almost losing something does that to you."

She paused. "Almost losing what?"

I smiled. "You."

And before I could lose the nerve, I slipped the letter onto her desk and walked away.

I did not wait for her to read it. I could not.

I sat two rows down, hands clammy, heart threatening to tear through my chest.

Minutes passed.

Then—

A hand tapped my shoulder.

I turned.

She was holding the letter.

"I know this is from you."

I said nothing.

She sat beside me.

And for the first time, she did not speak right away. Just stared out the window, eyes stormy with thought.

Finally, she whispered, *"What if stars collide, though?"*

I swallowed. *"Then let them. At least they'll finally know what it means to be close."*

She looked at me for a long time.

And in that moment, something opened between us. A gate I had waited for a lifetime to see swing wide.

We did not hold hands.

We just sat there, in silence.

But it was not silence, really.

It was everything I had ever wanted to say finally resting in the space between us, heard without being spoken.

I knew then: this story was no longer a rewrite.

It was becoming something entirely new.

And this time I would not let it slip away.

Chapter 12

In Another Universe—Maybe…

JinAm

Time did not stop.

It simply drifted forward without mercy, the way rivers forget the names of stones they once caressed.

Graduation came with a cruel smile.

We wore ribbons and medals and practiced smiling for photographs, as if snapshots could save us from the silence we both saw coming. I stood beside her, hand just inches from hers, heart already in mourning.

We were both accepted into senior high schools… different ones.

Different districts.

Different uniforms.

Different universes.

She got into a prestigious humanities program uptown. I stayed near home, a science high school that promised good things for good boys who studied hard and said little.

No one said the word "Goodbye."

Maybe we thought not saying it would make it less real.

Maybe we were cowards.

I remember our last day in junior high like it was a funeral in disguise. The sun was high, and our friends were laughing, throwing paper planes and confetti in the air. We hugged teachers, scrawled messages on uniforms. *"Don't forget me." "Let's meet again." Stay weird."*

She stood by the gate.

I walked to her, pretending my hands were not shaking.

"Hey," I said.

She turned, eyes already glassy. *"Hey."*

There was so much to say.

So much I could not.

"You're gonna be amazing," I said instead.

She smiled. *"You too."*

"Don't forget me, okay?"

Her voice cracked: *"Idiot. Why would I?"*

I wanted to hug her.

I wanted to scream at the sky and beg for more time.

I wanted to run.

But all I did was pull out a folded note from my pocket and press it into her hand.

She blinked. *"What's this?"*

"Something to read when it's quiet," I whispered.

And then, like cowards do, I walked away before she could open it.

The world after her was quieter.

Not because she was gone. But because I carried her absence like a cathedral in my chest.

Every new hallway in my new school felt like a test: Is she here?

Of course not.

Every corner reminded me of her laughter, and every classroom echoed with the ghosts of what we never said.

I texted her sometimes.

"Hope your classes are okay."

"They made us dissect frogs today. It was gross."

"I passed my first math quiz. Miracle happen."

Sometimes she replied.

But more often, the silence stretched longer. Not cruel, just… distant.

It was never the right time to say the right things.

So I buried myself in books, in grades, in achievements that felt like paper castles. And all the while, I rewrote that day in my head.

What if I told her? What if I asked her to stay?

What if we chose each other over the current?

In another universe—maybe…

One afternoon, months later, I found myself walking near her school. I did not plan it. My feet had a memory of their own, and they took me there like a prayer.

She was there.

Across the street. Laughing with new friends. Her uniform fit like it belonged. She was radiant in a way I had not seen before. Growing into herself.

I did not call out.

I just stood there, invisible.

And then, by some cruel twist of the universe, she looked up and saw me.

For a heartbeat, the world stilled.

Recognition. Surprise. A thousand unspoken things in a single glance.

She smiled.

I waved.

And that was it.

She turned back to the sky.

Years passed.

I dated. She did too.

We lived parallel lives, always almost touching.

The kind that makes you wonder if the stars ever weep for the lovers they misalign.

Sometimes, I would find her name in old notebooks. Or hear a song that sounded like her laugh. Or wake up from dream I forgot too quickly.

And each time, I'd whisper, *"In another universe—maybe."*

In another universe, I never let go.

In another universe, I ran after her that day.

In another universe, I hugged her when it mattered.

But here?

Here, we are pages in the same book, never touching, only echoing.

And that has to be enough.

For now.

Chapter 13

The Constellation of Return

JinAm

The stage lights glared down like little suns, catching the golden tassel of my cap as I stood still among the crowd. My name echoed through the speakers. Applause followed, but my mind was not in the gymnasium.

It was drifting—through time, through memory.

"Graduated with High Honors and Best in Research," the emcee announced.

I walked forward. My shoes made soft taps on the hardwood floor. My body moved, automatic and composed, but my heart thudded with something deeper than pride.

Because this was not just a diploma.

This was proof that I had not let go of the promise

Not to the world. Not to my family.

Not to her.

Senior high school had been a quiet battlefield.

We went to different schools. Different uniforms. Different commutes. No more accidental encounters in hallways. No more exchanging glances across the room.

But I did not let her vanish.

I could not.

I followed her through her posts, her art, her digital footprints that hinted at laughter and sleepless nights. I cheered her silently through her milestones. I did not dare to message too often, just enough to remind her I existed. That I remembered.

That I waited.

And in the silence of my own academic grind, I bloomed.

I buried myself in debate, in science fairs, in research work that won medals. I joined campus organizations and served my batch with the same quiet intensity I had once reserved only for her.

I learned how to speak on stages, to lead projects, to endure failure without crumbling. But every time I stood at the edge of a spotlight, I still imagined her in the crowd, watching.

And now, at the close of senior high school, I had built a boy worthy of being seen.

College was a different storm.

I entered a sea of unfamiliar faces, each student a world in motion. First year swept me up in endless lectures and initiation rites, in forming friendships forged over all-nighters and cold vending machine coffee.

I ran for a student council position, unsure if anyone would vote for the quiet guys who always sat near the back.

They did.

Second year tested me harder. My responsibilities piled high—student leader by day, struggling scholar by night. My dreams whispered louder when sleep eluded me: her voice in memory, her silhouette in the stars outside the dorm window.

Still, I showed up. For my orgs, for my groupmates, for every student who needed someone who would not flinch.

And in third year, I found my rhythm.

I organized charity events. Mediated meetings. Balanced the wild hum of student politics with my own aching wish: to find her again before this all ended.

And then came the fourth year.

It began like an ordinary semester. Government OJT placements were released late at night, names printed in ugly black ink. My eyes scanned the list like a hunter tracking a heartbeat in the forest.

And then I saw it.

Her name. My name. Same department.

Fate was not subtle anymore.

The morning of our orientation, I arrived early, nerves rattling like dice in my chest. I wore the formal attire we were told to bring—tie tight, shoes polished, soul on fire.

The moment she walked in, time lost meaning.

Same hair, just longer now. Same eyes, though maybe more tired. Same presence that could still silence the noise of a hundred crowded rooms.

She had not seen me yet.

I stood up.

"Hey," I said.

She turned.

And the look on her face—surprise, recognition, and something like a whisper of joy—unfolded like a sunrise.

"Oh my God," she said. *"It's really you."*

I smiled. *"Told you I'd catch up."*

She stared at me, disbelieving. *"You look different."*

"So do you."

"No, I mean…" She trailed off, eyes scanning my face like she was trying to find the boy I used to be. *"You really grew up."*

I did not say anything. I just looked at her—truly, openly—for the first time in years.

And at that pause, the years between us did not vanish.

They aligned.

Like stars.

We were assigned to the same department. Not because of luck, but because something bigger had finally bent toward mercy.

We walked the halls of government buildings like old souls trapped in a new beginning. We policies, drafted minutes, files reports. But every lunch break was a return to our old language—shared glances, half-teased memories, words that danced around everything we wanted to say.

One afternoon, we sat by the agency garden. The wind was soft. The world was quiet.

"I missed this," she said.

"What?"

"You. Your weird metaphors. Your eyes when you talk about things you care about. You used to hide them. But now…" She smiled faintly. *"You don't anymore."*

I took a breath. This was it.

"I waited for this," I said. *"For you."*

She looked at me—no mockery, no disbelief. Just that open silence that always came before the truth.

"I wanted to reach out," she whispered. *"So many times. But I thought maybe you forgot. Or moved on."*

"I never moved on."

"I was scared you wouldn't remember me the way I remembered you."

"I remembered everything," I said. *"Every laugh. Every time you call me weird. Every day I walked home and wished I had the guts to walk beside you."*

She blinked, tears forming.

"I wanted that too," she said. *"Back then."*

I reached for her hand, slow, deliberate.

And This time—

She did not pull away.

That night, I walked home under a sky so clear I thought the heavens had been scrubbed clean.

We are different people now.

But somehow, we found our way back.

Not as children clinging to memories, but as people who had built themselves from heartbreak, from silence, from the long ache of separation.

This time, we were together.

Not because we had to be.

But because, after everything, we chose to be.

And for the first time in a long time, long life—

I was not afraid of the future anymore.

Chapter 14

In Quiet Hours

JinAm

Our days blurred together, each one folding into the next like pages in a long, dense book of paperwork and policy drafts. The office hummed with the dull, persistent hum of the bureaucracy, the tapping of keyboards, the shuffle of printed reports, the murmur of hushed conversations filtered through thin cubicle walls. But beneath the monotony, a quiet current ran between us—subtle, almost imperceptible to anyone else, but electric to those who understood.

She sat across from me in the cramped cubicle we shared, often lost in thought as she chewed on the cap of her pen, a little nervous habit I had come to memorize like a secret code. Her eyes would narrow as she deciphered the dense legislative texts, her brows furrowing in concentration, and I caught myself watching her, memorizing the curve o her fingers, the way her lashes brushed her cheeks when she blinked, the slight tension in her jaw when a sentence made no sense.

We were no longer just two people connected by a fragile thread of childhood memories. We were something more, something present, tangible, real. The slow unfolding of familiarity and newness at the same time.

Our conversation were no longer tentative or filled with awkward silences. Instead, they became the rhythm that carried us through long days—shared jokes about the absurdities of government work, exchanged stories about college professors who were monsters or mentors, dreams we were starting to dare to say aloud.

Sometimes, after long days filled with meetings and report writing, we walked home together. Not every day, only when the city felt a little less heavy, when the world seemed softer somehow, and the tension that hung in my shoulders eased just enough to let me breathe.

Those walks were quiet at first, the city noises around us muffled as we found comfort in each other's presence. But slowly, the silence filled with words, about the future, about hopes once buried under years of uncertainty, about "when we" and "someday" instead of the distant "what if."

One evening, wrapped in the warm golden hush of Manila sunset, she turned to me with a smile, soft and wistful, eyes reflecting the fading light.

"Did you ever think we'd end up like this?" she asked.

I hesitated, because the truth was complicated. The boy I once had dreamed of this moment would answer yes, but the man I had become had learned that life rarely handed out happy ending so easily.

"I did," I said slowly, *"I hoped."*

She laughed, a sound like wind chimes stirred by a gentle breeze. *"I used to pray I'd meet you again. But I never imagined it'd feel this easy."*

I shook my head, a small smile playing on my lips. *"It wasn't always easy. But it was always worth it."*

Our little sanctuary became the garden on the roof of the government office—a hidden patch of green in the concrete jungle where the world's noise softened. What started as quick lunch breaks turned into moments we did not want to end. We lingered longer, sharing food and laughter beneath the trees, the sunlight filtering through the leaves like blessings.

Our connection grew in the quiet moments. The way she waited patiently when I stayed late finishing a report, the way I learned to bring her coffee exactly how she liked it—black with a splash of milk, and right amount of sugar enough to be sweet—without her needing to remind me.

Once, during a fierce thunderstorm that rattled the windows and plunged the building into flickering darkness, she flinched at the sudden crack of thunder.

I laughed gently, stepping closer. *"Still scared of thunder?"*

"Only when I'm alone," she whispered, eyes wide.

I held out my hand. Without hesitation, she took it.

And from that moment on, it stayed that way.

Day by day, trust blossomed in the spaces between our conversations. Love took root in the silence, in the shared smiles, in the hands that found each other before words were even spoken,

She was not the shy, distant girl from my past life anymore.

She was here.

In my present.

Sometimes, we revisited the stories of junior high—hallway glances that once felt like lifetimes, moments frozen in time that we never had the courage to speak about. We mourned the years we lost, not with bitterness, but with tenderness born of knowing how precious the now really was.

One cool night, we wandered through quiet streets after dinner, the city lights casting soft halos around us.

"You've changed so much," she said, voice filled with awe.

"I had to," I answered. *"Back then, I wasn't brave enough to love you out loud."*

She stopped walking and looked up at me, the streetlights framing her face like a portrait.

"And now?"

I turned to face her fully, the world around us falling away. The noise of the city dimmed, leaving only the sound of our breathing.

"Now," I said softly,*" I'd shout it from every corner of the world—if you'd let me."*

Her eyes shimmered with unshed tears, a delicate smile on her lips.

"You don't have to shout," she whispered. *"I hear you. I always did."*

And just like that, her fingers slipped between mine—a quiet promise.

No grand declarations were needed. We already knew.

What we had was not built on fireworks or grand gestures.

It was built in the spaces between—on patience, on becoming, on choosing to stay when letting go would have been easier.

So, amid the ticking clocks, the endless files, and the relentless grind of government service, love bloomed in the simplest, most profound ways: shared umbrellas against sudden rains, synchronized footsteps on quiet streets, and eyes that spoke volumes before a single word was uttered.

The past had brought us here,

But now, finally, we had the present.

And a future that felt like it belonged to us.

Chapter 15

The End of the Beginning

JinAm

The morning sun filtered softly through the tall windows of the grand auditorium, casting long golden beams across the sea of faces gathered for the graduation ceremony. The air buzzed with quiet anticipation, hushed whispers, the rustle of caps and gowns, the occasional nervous laugh. But beneath all that, there was weight, too. The weight of years wrapped in hopes, struggles, sacrifices, and dreams finally converging into this single day.

I sat among my classmates, my heart a tempest of emotions: relief, nostalgia, and a deep, unshakeable gratitude. Each breath I took was heavy with the memory of every sleepless night, every challenge that had once seemed insurmountable, every moment I had doubted myself and yet pressed on,

The moment arrived with sharp clarity. My name was called.

"Jin Fernandez."

The sound of my name echoed through the hall like a bell tolling the end of a long journey. Rising from my seat, I felt the eyes of the crowd fix on me, but it was the gaze of one person that steadied me—a beacon amidst the sea of faces. She was there, sitting quietly but confidently, her eyes locked on me, glowing with a light I had chased through the darkest nights.

Each step toward the stage felt like walking through a dream. The applause thundered, a roaring wave of sound washing over me, but it was her smile that carried me forward. It was real. She was real. She was here.

As I reached the podium, the dean handed me my diploma. It was more than a piece of paper. It was proof, proof of every sacrifices, every hard-earned lesson. But the true honor came moments later when I received the leadership award, a recognition of my years serving as a student council officer. A testament to the growth I had fought so hard to achieve.

And yet, in that moment, the award felt small compared to the feeling of her pride shining through her eyes, her silent cheers louder than any applause.

After the ceremony, outside under a sky brushed with soft clouds and the golden glow of the afternoon, we found each other again. Time seemed to slow, the world shrinking until it was only the two of us.

"You did it, Jin." she said, her voice trembling just slightly, revealing the depth of the emotions she held back.

I took her hands in mine, feeling the warmth, the steady pulse of life and hope. *"We did it."* I whispered. Because none of this was mine alone. It was ours. Every step, every stumble, every victory.

Her smile broke through, radiant and free, a light I vowed never to let fade.

The days that followed were filled with quiet moments of reflection and joy. I watched her graduate, seated among the crowd with swelling pride and awe. When her name was called and she walked across the stage, my heart swelled with fierce, protective love. She was radiant, strong, brilliant, and more beautiful than ever.

After her ceremony, we stood together beneath the wide-open sky, the city humming softly around us.

"Ready for the next chapter?" she asked, eyes sparkling with hope and promise.

I pulled her close, feeling the steady beat of her heart against mine, a rhythm I wanted to carry forever.

"With you, always" I promised.

In that embrace, I understood that this was not the end of a story but the beginning of everything we dared together. The past, with its mistakes and regrets, had shaped up, but it no longer defined us. Now, we held the pen, ready to write a future forged from love, resilience, and shared strength.

As the sun dipped below the horizon, painting the sky in hues of amber and violet, I felt a quiet certainty settle within me: whatever challenges awaited, whatever paths we would take, we would face them side by side.

This was our new beginning.

Epilogue

The Life After the Last

JinAm

There are two lives I remember living.

The first was a quiet tragedy. A life where I loved from afar, where I let the days pass me by while she glowed in a world I never dared to enter. I spent that lifetime chasing greatness for a girl who never knew my name—until the end, when my heart stopped just as hers finally turned to look.

And the, somehow, I was given a second life.

In this one, I did not wait. I did not hide. I faced every storm and carved a path with bare hands and burning hope. I became the man I had once only dreamed of becoming—not for her, but with her. Every step was hard-earned, every failure a stone toward something whole. I remembered everything from my first life. The silence. Regret. The ache of words never said. And I swore not to repeat it.

So I rose. I earned honors in senior high school—Best in Research, High Honors—but they meant more because I did it… for her. In college, I served in the student council, fought for others, gave everything I had, and each time I looked up, I found her there, even when we were miles apart. We walked separate roads but always glanced in the same direction.

And finally, in fourth year of college, destiny circled back. We reunited during our government OJT, just like before—but this time, I did not freeze. I did not let the moment slip. I held her hand.

We fell in love not just because we could, but because we were finally brave enough to do so.

I graduated top of my class. Draped in sashes of leadership and honors, but all I truly saw that day was her in the crowd, eyes gleaming with pride. She had made it too—she stood on her own stage later, and I was there in the front row, heart swelling like a tide. We watched each other grow. We had fought to become the people we needed to be.

Now, with no more exams, no more uniforms, no more pretending, we stand as we are.

And I sometimes wonder… Was the first life a punishment? A test? A dream?

No.

It was a lesson.

A painful, beautiful reminder that love is not just about fate, it is about courage. About effort. About returning when you have been broken and still choosing the same person all over again.

I loved her in silence once.

Now, I love her out loud, with every breath, every word, every tomorrow.

And that is the life I choose to live, now and always.

[redacted]

A Novel

Requiem

For the

Unfiled Motion

He spent a lifetime becoming the man deserving of a woman, only to lose everything in a heartbeat.

A story of unspoken love and crushing weight of "too late", until the clock resets. Waking with the memories of a life lost to regret, a boy is granted a desperate second chance to rewrite fate. No longer content watching from a distance, he must now use his resolve to bridge the gap between what was lost and what could be, fighting to claim a place beside the girl who unknowingly inspired him before the time runs out.

JinAm

Time is the enemy of a heart that hesitates.